Movement had been implemented, and they should not miss this opportunity of putting forward the views of the Indian people. He also said that of the five members who had voted with him for state management of the railways on the Acworth Committee, three were European, though in this case he was not so sanguine because the ‘vested interests that are likely to be affected by a just policy of the Commission are much more grave and serious for the other side.’[9] Purshotamdas, given his views, was doomed to be a minority of one and submitted a Minute of dissent.

The Hilton Young Commission was the last of the formal currency inquiries in British India. It differed from its predecessors in two important respects. Firstly, it had four Indian members while the earlier Commissions had one or none at all. Secondly, it was the first to travel to India to hear local evidence. Both departures reflected the need to make concessions given the fact that Indian businessmen who had experienced deflation in the course of the rupee’s rise to 1s 6d were convinced that only a full-fledged automatic gold standard could prevent a repetition of the problems of the preceding decade and secure monetary autonomy from Whitehall.

Although a gold standard had the support of a majority of Indian businessmen, Purshotamdas and other Bombay businessmen were the most prominent heirs to this tradition. They shared London’s unhappiness at India’s large gold imports during 1923–25 because these reduced the demand for cotton-piece goods and diverted funds from productive investment. Purshotamdas blamed large gold imports on the 2s rate due to which the government offered only ₹10 for the sovereign even though the market price was considerably higher. It also prevented gold imports from leading to a selfcorrecting expansion of currency. Purshotamdas believed that gold hoarding began in India only after it was demonetized by the East India Company in 1830–35 and argued that its remonetization would arrest or reverse the trend. But Britain haunted by fears of gold shortage and faced with severe internal and external economic imbalances, remained implacably opposed to a gold standard for India.

While London remained unmoved, an automatically functioning gold standard was a long-standing aspiration not only of Indian businessmen like Purshotamdas, but also numbered among its adherents, officials in Delhi. Sir Basil Blackett, the Finance Member, who for long boasted the most impeccable anti-gold standard credentials was ‘converted’ and breaking